

D267

US History: Stories of American Democracy

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

Under the first national government after independence, Congress met in Philadelphia and later in other cities, each state had one vote, and Congress could only ask the states for money. In 1786, indebted farmers in western Massachusetts rose up against farm foreclosures, and the national government could not raise an army to respond. Which weakness did this expose?

- A. The national government lacked the power to tax and to enforce its laws.
- B. The national government was too strong and overpowered the states.
- C. The president used the veto too often.
- D. Congress moved between too many cities to govern well.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A bill passed both houses of Congress after months of hearings covered by national newspapers. The president vetoed it. Two-thirds of each house then voted to pass it again. The bill's sponsor had served in the Senate for eighteen years. What is the result?

- A. The bill becomes law only if three-fourths of the states ratify it.
- B. The bill is dead, because a presidential veto is final.
- C. The bill becomes law; the override is Congress's check on the president.
- D. The bill goes to the Supreme Court for approval before taking effect.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which is an example of federalism rather than separation of powers?

- A. States run their own public school systems while the national government coins money.
- B. The Supreme Court strikes down a law passed by Congress.
- C. The Senate must confirm the president's nominees to federal courts.
- D. The president commands the military while Congress declares war.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

In 1868, while federal troops still occupied parts of the South and cotton prices were falling, the states ratified an amendment declaring that all persons born or naturalized in the United States are citizens and that no state may deny any person equal protection of the laws. Which amendment is this?

- A. The Thirteenth Amendment.
- B. The Fourteenth Amendment.
- C. The First Amendment, because it protects individual rights.
- D. The Fifteenth Amendment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which amendment barred the federal and state governments from denying the right to vote because of race, color, or previous condition of servitude?

- A. The Fourteenth Amendment.
- B. The Thirteenth Amendment.
- C. The Fifteenth Amendment.
- D. The Nineteenth Amendment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

By 1919, women could already vote in many western states, and in Wyoming they had voted since 1869. Activists had picketed the White House during a world war. In 1920, what change did the Nineteenth Amendment make?

- A. It gave women the vote only in the western states.
- B. It guaranteed every adult the vote regardless of race, sex, or tax payment.
- C. It ended wartime limits on protests near the White House.
- D. It barred the federal and state governments from denying the vote on account of sex, nationwide.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A Louisiana law required separate railroad cars for Black and white passengers. In 1896 the Supreme Court upheld the law. The train in the test case ran between New Orleans and Covington. What doctrine did the Court establish?

- A. Only Congress may regulate interstate railroads.
- B. Segregated public schools are inherently unequal.
- C. Rail lines between two cities must be run by the federal government.
- D. "Separate but equal": segregation was allowed if the facilities were equal.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In 1954 the Supreme Court ruled that separate public schools for Black and white children were inherently unequal. Which earlier ruling did this decision reject for public education?

- A. Brown v. Board of Education.
- B. Plessy v. Ferguson.
- C. Dred Scott v. Sandford.
- D. Marbury v. Madison.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

In 1887 Congress passed a law dividing reservation land into individual allotments, often 160 acres per head of household, with remaining land opened to settlers. The law's sponsor chaired the Senate committee on Indian affairs, and the bill was signed in February. What was the main goal of the policy?

- A. To assimilate Native Americans by breaking up tribal landholding and pushing individual farming.
- B. To strengthen tribal self-government.
- C. To move eastern tribes west of the Mississippi River.
- D. To reward the committee chair's home state with new farmland.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which federal law ended allotment and encouraged tribes to restore their own governments?

- A.** The Indian Removal Act of 1830.
- B.** The Indian Reorganization Act of 1934.
- C.** The Dawes Act of 1887.
- D.** The Homestead Act of 1862.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

In 1935, with unemployment near 20 percent, Congress passed a law creating federal old-age insurance funded by payroll taxes and a federal-state unemployment insurance system. That spring, huge dust storms had also swept the southern Plains. How did this law change the role of the federal government?

- A.** It gave direct aid to farmers hurt by the dust storms.
- B.** It shrank federal power by handing relief to private charities.
- C.** It made the federal government lastingly responsible for parts of individual economic security.
- D.** It guaranteed every American a government job.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

In 1882, after Chinese workers had helped build the western section of the first transcontinental railroad, Congress passed a law suspending the immigration of Chinese laborers. What made this law a turning point in U.S. immigration policy?

- A.** It ended federal funding for railroad building.
- B.** It opened immigration to all Asian nations.
- C.** It created the national-origins quota system.
- D.** It was the first federal law to bar immigrants of a specific nationality.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

Under the first national government after independence, Congress ~~met in Philadelphia and later in other cities~~, each state had one vote, and Congress could only ask the states for money. In 1786, indebted farmers in western Massachusetts rose up against farm foreclosures, and the national government could not raise an army to respond. Which weakness did this expose?

Target word: the structural weakness **Decides:** Congress could only request money and could not act on its own.

A	Correct	Without taxing power it could not fund an army or respond to the uprising.
B	Inverted operation	The problem was the reverse: it was too weak.
C	Confusion set	There was no president under the Articles; that office came with the Constitution.
D	Camouflage	Meeting places did not decide the government's lack of power.

2. Answer C Concept 2

A bill passed both houses of Congress ~~after months of hearings covered by national newspapers~~. The president vetoed it. Two-thirds of each house then voted to pass it again. ~~The bill's sponsor had served in the Senate for eighteen years~~. What is the result?

Target word: outcome of a veto override **Decides:** Two-thirds of both houses overrides a veto.

A	Confusion set	State ratification applies to constitutional amendments, not ordinary laws.
B	Absolute language	A veto can be overridden.
C	Correct	A two-thirds vote in both houses overrides a veto.
D	Adjacent category	Courts review laws only when a case is brought, not as a step in passage.

3. Answer A Concept 2 · transfer

Which is an example of federalism rather than separation of powers?

Target word: federalism example — reverse of a branch-vs-branch check **Decides:** Power split between national and state levels.

A	Correct	A division of power between levels of government is federalism.
B	Confusion set	Judicial review is a check among branches, not a national-state division.
C	Inverted operation	That is one federal branch checking another: separation of powers.
D	Adjacent category	Shared war powers are split among branches, not levels.

4. Answer B Concept 3

In 1868, ~~while federal troops still occupied parts of the South and cotton prices were falling~~, the states ratified an amendment declaring that all persons born or naturalized in the United States are citizens and that no state may deny any person equal protection of the laws. Which amendment is this?

Target word: name the amendment **Decides:** Citizenship plus equal protection = 14th.

A	Confusion set	The 13th (1865) abolished slavery.
B	Correct	It defined citizenship and guaranteed equal protection.
C	Adjacent category	The 1st protects speech, religion, and press, not citizenship or equal protection.
D	Confusion set	The 15th (1870) protected voting from racial discrimination.

5. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

Which amendment barred the federal and state governments from denying the right to vote because of race, color, or previous condition of servitude?

Target word: voting and race — solve for the amendment from its content **Decides:** Race-based voting bar = 15th.

A	Confusion set	The 14th covers citizenship and equal protection.
B	Dropped element	Ending slavery did not by itself protect voting rights.
C	Correct	Ratified in 1870, it addressed voting and race.
D	Adjacent category	The 19th addressed voting and sex, not race.

6. Answer D Concept 4

By 1919, women could already vote in many western states, and in Wyoming they had voted since 1869. ~~Activists had picketed the White House during a world war.~~ In 1920, what change did the Nineteenth Amendment make?

Target word: what the 19th did **Decides:** A nationwide bar on sex-based denial of the vote.

A	Dropped element	Drops the nationwide reach; western states already allowed it.
B	Absolute language	Poll taxes and Jim Crow laws still blocked many voters, especially Black women in the South.
C	Camouflage	The protests are a background detail, not what the amendment did.
D	Correct	That is the amendment's text and reach.

7. Answer D Concept 5

A Louisiana law required separate railroad cars for Black and white passengers. In 1896 the Supreme Court upheld the law. ~~The train in the test case ran between New Orleans and Covington.~~ What doctrine did the Court establish?

Target word: doctrine of the 1896 ruling **Decides:** Upheld segregation if facilities were equal.

A	Adjacent category	A commerce question; the case turned on equal protection and segregation.
B	Inverted operation	That is Brown v. Board of Education (1954), which rejected Plessy's doctrine in schools.
C	Camouflage	The route is a detail that did not decide the ruling.
D	Correct	Plessy v. Ferguson upheld segregation under that doctrine.

8. Answer B Concept 5 • transfer

In 1954 the Supreme Court ruled that separate public schools for Black and white children were inherently unequal. Which earlier ruling did this decision reject for public education?

Target word: which ruling was rejected — reverse direction **Decides:** Brown overturned Plessy's doctrine in schools.

A	Inverted operation	That is the 1954 ruling itself, not the one it rejected.
B	Correct	Brown rejected "separate but equal" in public education.
C	Adjacent category	Dred Scott was undone by the 14th Amendment, not by Brown.
D	Confusion set	Marbury (1803) set up judicial review; it was not overturned.

9. Answer A Concept 6

In 1887 Congress passed a law dividing reservation land into individual allotments, often 160 acres per head of household, with remaining land opened to settlers. ~~The law's sponsor chaired the Senate committee on Indian affairs, and the bill was signed in February.~~ What was the main goal of the policy?

Target word: goal of allotment **Decides:** Breaking up tribal land to force individual farming and assimilation.

A	Correct	Allotment aimed at assimilation and cost tribes most of their land.
B	Inverted operation	That was the goal of the 1934 Indian Reorganization Act, which ended allotment.
C	Confusion set	That was the Indian Removal Act of 1830.
D	Camouflage	Who sponsored the bill does not decide its national goal.

10. Answer B Concept 6 · transfer

Which federal law ended allotment and encouraged tribes to restore their own governments?

Target word: the reversal law **Decides:** 1934 Indian Reorganization Act.

A	Confusion set	That law forced tribes west.
B	Correct	It stopped allotment and supported tribal self-government.
C	Inverted operation	That law created allotment.
D	Adjacent category	It gave public land to settlers; it was not tribal policy.

11. Answer C Concept 7

In 1935, with unemployment near 20 percent, Congress passed a law creating federal old-age insurance funded by payroll taxes and a federal-state unemployment insurance system. ~~That spring, huge dust storms had also swept the southern Plains.~~ How did this law change the role of the federal government?

Target word: change in federal role **Decides:** National insurance programs made Washington responsible for economic security.

A	Camouflage	Farm relief came through other programs; the dust storms do not describe this law.
B	Inverted operation	The law expanded federal responsibility.
C	Correct	Social Security created permanent national insurance programs.
D	Absolute language	It created insurance programs, not a job guarantee.

12. Answer D Concept 8

In 1882, ~~after Chinese workers had helped build the western section of the first transcontinental railroad,~~ Congress passed a law suspending the immigration of Chinese laborers. What made this law a turning point in U.S. immigration policy?

Target word: why it was a turning point **Decides:** First federal law barring a specific nationality.

A	Camouflage	The railroad detail is background, not the law's effect.
B	Inverted operation	It restricted immigration.
C	Confusion set	Quotas came with the Immigration Act of 1924.
D	Correct	That is why historians treat it as a turning point.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	2	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	10	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Why the Articles failed	The Articles of Confederation created a weak central government that could not tax, regulate trade, or enforce laws, which led to the Constitution.	Thinking the first national government was too strong.	A crisis the national government could not pay for or respond to in the 1780s.
2	Separation of powers vs. federalism	Separation of powers splits authority among the three federal branches, which check each other; federalism divides power between the national and state governments.	Calling any power-sharing arrangement checks and balances.	Branch vs. branch (separation) or nation vs. state (federalism).
3	Reconstruction Amendments	The 13th ended slavery, the 14th defined citizenship and guaranteed equal protection, and the 15th barred denying the vote because of race.	Mixing up which amendment did which.	Citizenship or equal protection (14th); voting and race (15th); slavery (13th).
4	Expanding the vote	The 19th Amendment (1920) barred denying the vote on account of sex nationwide, but other barriers such as Jim Crow laws still blocked many voters.	Assuming one amendment gave every adult the vote at once.	“Nationwide” or “all women” and the year 1920.
5	Plessy to Brown	Plessy v. Ferguson (1896) upheld “separate but equal”; Brown v. Board of Education (1954) held that segregated public schools are inherently unequal.	Reversing which case allowed and which rejected segregation.	1896 railroad car vs. 1954 public schools.
6	Federal Indian policy shifts	Removal (1830) forced tribes west; allotment under the Dawes Act (1887) broke up tribal land to force assimilation; the Indian Reorganization Act (1934) ended allotment and supported tribal self-government.	Treating every policy as having the same goal or mixing up their order.	Moving tribes (removal), dividing land (allotment), restoring self-government (reorganization).
7	New Deal and federal responsibility	The New Deal, including the Social Security Act of 1935, made the federal government permanently responsible for parts of individual economic security.	Thinking the New Deal reduced federal power or guaranteed everyone a job.	1930s laws creating national insurance or relief programs.
8	Immigration restriction	The Chinese Exclusion Act (1882) was the first federal law to bar immigrants of a specific nationality; the 1924 act later set national-origins quotas.	Confusing the 1882 exclusion with the 1924 quota system.	“First” law barring a group, or quotas based on national origin.

Course scope (public description): This course presents a broad survey of U.S. history from early colonization to the mid-twentieth century. The course explores how historical events and major themes in American history have affected diverse populations, influenced changes in policy and established the American definition of

democracy. This course consists of an introduction and five major sections. Each section includes learning opportunities through reading, images, videos, and other relevant resources. Assessment activities with feedback also provide opportunities to practice and check how well you understand the content. Because the course is self-paced, you may move through the material as quickly or as slowly as you need to, with the goal of demonstrating proficiency in the five competencies covered in the final assessment. If you have no prior knowledge of this material, you can expect to spend 30-40 hours on the course content.